

A GENERATIONAL BATTLE

A youthful English squad goes up against an ageing Australian unit determined to defend its turf **one last time.**

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Off-the-field banter enlivens professional sport, lending context and raising the stakes. It sets up a narrative, leaving it to the players to validate or undo it. Even cricket's oldest rivalry needs the needle of the customary argy-bargy between player-turned-pundits and fans every time Australia and England face off in the biennial Ashes.

But criticism hits close to home when it originates from one's own, prompting introspection and honest self-reckoning. The Ashes down under comes at a time when the rivals, though from different hemispheres and schools of thought, are at a crossroads.

Australia's greying squad, with an average age of 33, is deemed inconducive to a smooth transition. By contrast, England's marauding Bazballers, averaging just 28, need to prove back home that their revolution is bearing fruit.

Five long summers separate the two teams, and almost as much time has elapsed since England's last port of call on balmy Australian shores, in January 2022, when a hopelessly timid visiting team was handed a 0-4 hiding.

It is charmingly poetic that England, under the new captain-coach combination of Ben Stokes and Brendon McCullum, rose like a phoenix from that very Ashes drubbing and the subsequent loss of face in the Caribbean.

The only salvation it could retrieve from the wreckage of that Australian tour — a draw, and a defiant one, in Sydney — is now sacrilege for